A few days later, Johnson chose a moment when the two were alone together to make his offer. ‘As I have become pretty intimate with our commandant,’ he wrote, ‘I took advantage of no third person being within hearing to whisper in his ear that we would give him a mountain of rupees, if instead of carrying us to Bameean, he would take us in the opposite direction towards General Nott’s army, extolling the delights of Hindoostan should he feel inclined to go there after liberating us. At first he seemed rather surprised at the proposition which I mooted half-jokingly half-seriously, not knowing in what way he might view it.’[66] Before long Saleh Mohammad had made it clear that ‘he wished to know what we would do for our liberation’, and asked the prisoners to make a serious offer.[67]

Negotiations continued after the party arrived in Bamiyan, aided by a series of promissory notes sent by the ever-resourceful Mohan Lal, which he arranged through his Qizilbash friends in Kabul. When a letter arrived from Akbar Khan ordering Saleh Mohammad Khan to move the hostages still further north, to Khulm, Lawrence raised his bid and offered to make him an immediate down-payment of 20,000 rupees in cash and a monthly payment thereafter for life of Rs 1,000. As ‘Ata Mohammad put it: ‘“Gold is a wonderful substance: the sight of it gladdens the eye; the sound of it drives away melancholy.” The offer turned the Khan’s head, and he prepared to have the prisoners set free.’[68]

Aided by Saleh Mohammad Khan, at a given signal the prisoners took over the fortress in which they were being held, offering their former guards four months’ extra pay if they helped defend it until they were rescued. When Saleh Mohammad handed the prisoners a pile of muskets to help with the defence, the prisoners were so surprised to have control over their own destinies after many passive months in captivity that at first none volunteered to join the guard – until Lady Sale stepped in. ‘Thinking the men might be shamed into doing their duty,’ she wrote later, ‘I said to Lawrence, “You had better give me one, and I will lead the party.”’[69]

Before long, under Lady Sale’s watchful eye, the hostages had gained sufficient confidence to run up the Union Jack on the flagpole. Pottinger then resumed his duties as political agent in Kohistan and called upon all the neighbouring chiefs to attend his durbar and receive dresses of honour. ‘Our conspiracy continues to prosper,’ wrote Johnson in his diary on 14 September.